

30 Minutes Expert In Search of a Codec

Got a video file that you can't play? Try this...

So you've just downloaded a video clip of a complete workshop, and Windows Media Player refuses to play it, and so does every player you download. Blame it on the missing codec.

So exactly which codec (coder-decoder) is your file missing? Ask the file! That's right. The first four bytes of a video file store information about the encoding process used. There are tools available on the Net that can read this information, telling you which codec is missing.

Gspot, available at <http://www.headbands.com/gspot/download.html>, is a tool that can be used to recognize the codec used to encode a video file. After installing Gspot on your system, you can start it from the **Start Menu > Programs > Gspot > Gspot Codec Information Application**. Open a video file by clicking on **File > Open**. The main window lists all the

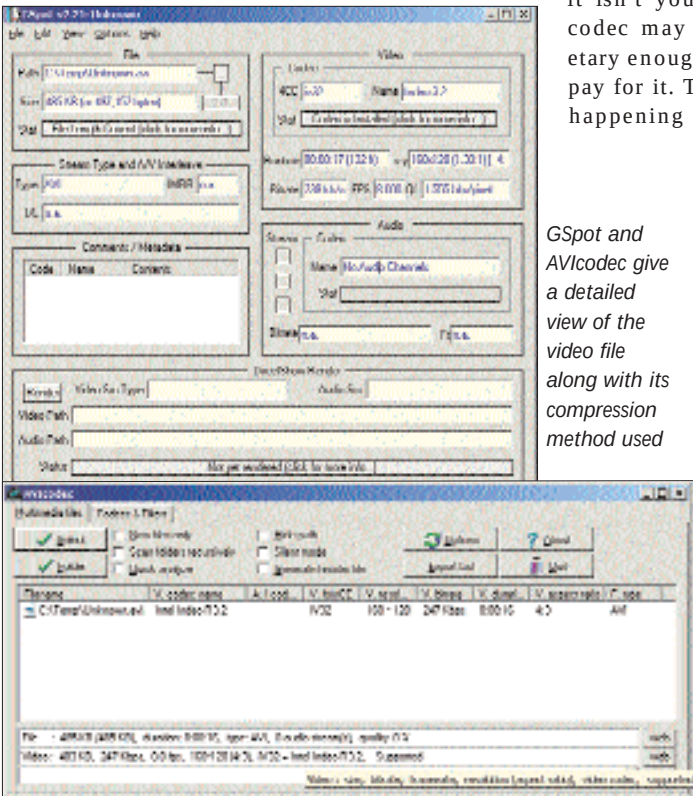
details of the video file open—it shows the codec using which the particular file was coded, the bit rate, the number of total frames, the frame rate, the video dimensions, and so on.

You can also use another program known as AVIcodec (<http://avicodec.duby.info/>), which has a more complex interface. It is similar to Gspot, but gives much detailed information such as the audio bitrate and the audio frequency.

Now that you know which codec your video file is missing, you can either download it, or download a media player that comes with its own codec pack. If it isn't your lucky day, your codec may be rare or proprietary enough to require you to pay for it. The chances of this happening are slim, since

codec packs such as Nimo codec pack, K-Lite, Elisoft codec pack, etc., are widely available for free. Never install more than one codec pack on your system, unless it's incomplete. This may lead to codec clashes or version mismatches, which will allow neither of the packs to play the file. Also, during installation, check whether

GSpot and AVIcodec give a detailed view of the video file along with its compression method used



Find it on the Mindware CD
GSpot v2.21, BSPlayer v0.86 build 500, Elisoft Codec pack v13.505



BSPlayer gives a lot of options for playback, while The Core Media Player has a very simple interface

the pack installs previous versions of the same codec such as DivX 3.x and 4.x. This confuses the player, and the system will not be able to play any DivX encoded files, even after uninstalling the codec pack. It is better to note the codec needed, and install it individually.

A better alternative is to use a third-party media player, which comes with its own codec pack. BSPlayer (www.bsplayer.org), one of the finest players a file can get—be it audio, video, or DVD. Not only does it come with its own codecs, every codec has been updated, so that you get only the latest versions. BSPlayer allows you to customize your viewable area ratio to 4:3, 16:9 or the original aspect ratios. Core Media Player (www.corecoded.com) is not as feature-rich as BSPlayer, but the interface is similar to Winamp. This player is light on system resources.

With all this codec control, there's nothing stopping you from watching your favourite movies. Happy viewing.

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